

Week 11: The Art of Biblical Poetry

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

Biblical poetry works differently than narrative — tonight we'll look at how, and why it rewards slowing down.

1. Do you gravitate toward poetry, or does it usually go over your head? Is there a song lyric, quote, or line of poetry that has stuck with you over the years? What makes it memorable?
2. **Read Exodus 15:1-21.** What images does this song use to describe what God did to Pharaoh's army and to the sea itself (vv. 4-10)? This song celebrates the exact same event told in narrative form just one chapter earlier — Israel crossing the sea on dry ground. Why do you think the Bible gives us both a plain account of what happened and a poetic song about it? What does the song let you feel that a simple retelling wouldn't?
3. Notice the intense, repeated imagery in the Song of the Sea — God's "right hand," the waters "piled up" like a wall, the sea "congealing." Poetry like this doesn't just report an event, it tries to recreate the experience of it. What's it like to read this as a participant rather than a bystander?
4. **Read Psalm 51.** Try reading verses 1-3 slowly, out loud if you can. Notice how the second line of each pair doesn't just repeat the first — "blot out my transgressions" sharpens "be gracious to me," and "cleanse me from my sin" intensifies "wash me thoroughly." What does slowing down like this change about how the confession lands, compared to skimming it once?
5. David uses several different images for sin and forgiveness in this psalm — stains that need washing, guilt that stands "ever before" him, a clean heart that needs to be created new. Why do you think one image wasn't enough for him? Which of these pictures for sin or forgiveness feels most true to your own experience?
6. **Read Isaiah 11:1-5.** What happens once the Spirit rests on this coming king, and what qualities does the passage say will mark him (vv. 2-5)? He's pictured as a "shoot" springing not from an existing royal branch, but from the "stump" and

"roots" of Jesse — David's father, not David himself. What do you think this odd image of new growth from old roots is trying to say about the kind of deliverer Israel actually needed?

7. Poetry is terse by design — it says more by using fewer, more carefully chosen words rather than explaining everything outright. Why might God have chosen to reveal so much of who he is, and so much of what he asks of us, through compressed poetry instead of straightforward prose?
8. If a third of the Bible is written to be slowed down and savored rather than read quickly for information, how does that change the way you typically approach your Bible reading, if at all?
9. Pick one line from Exodus 15, Psalm 51, or Isaiah 11 that stood out to you tonight. What would it look like to actually sit with that single line this week instead of moving on to the next chapter?